

Time In

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Siren's Song

IT'S ALL GREEK mythology to us, but it seems there was this famous soldier of fortune by the name of Ulysses who had himself one whale of an odyssey.

Ol' Ulysses went off to fight in the Trojan War and was some 20 or more years in returning home. It wasn't that he took a wrong turn at the traffic light. He just kept getting involved in some daring adventures.

In recounting the sagas to his faithful wife Penelope, Ulysses told how it was he had to deal with the likes of a cyclopes, lotus eaters and make his way through the narrowest and most storm-ravaged of sea passages, just to mention a few, to reach his front door again.

Penelope was overcome by the bravery of her husband and told him so: "Ulysses, that you survived such perils to reach my side is truly a magnificent conquest."

Ulysses, however, was heard to reply, "Shucks, my dear, it was all in a day's work."

But the University of Texas at El Paso baseball team could not be expected to brush off so lightly a recent display of valor in the first degree. Victories over Arizona State University have come too few and far between for that.

SO THE MINERS celebrated by holding a crash course in mayhem once their 7-5 win became official Friday. Roy Stringer, who hurled the triumph, tooted the loudest horn. Overlooked out of junior college by ASU scouts and naturally elated to show his wares so successfully, Stringer's voice would rise and fall and sometimes strike out on an inaudible course, one without any translation. And as much as that slow-moving sedated way of his would permit, Andy Cohen, the coach, reacted to the score in a style that would have made the Candid Camera top 10.

There was no bunting adorning the stands to confuse this particular game with a World Series. The Miners were simply overjoyed because they are U.T. El Paso and Arizona State is Arizona State and supposedly never the twain shall meet.

One of the hallmarks of college baseball, ASU in recent seasons has scheduled U.T. El Paso merely for batting practice purposes. And the Miners contributed to their own misery by going into a state of animation whenever ASU was the opposition. Grounders that should have been

routine outs cascaded off gloves like pins off a bowling ball. Outfielders camped under flies but come time to make the catch, it appeared as though they had been run off by a bear, or maybe the park ranger.

"I think we stood in awe too much of them," Cohen would say. "They looked good and played just like they looked and our players froze up."

But in going into the den this last time to play ASU, something seemed out of place. "It's not supposed to be this way," one ASU player said in disbelief after the Miners came back to tie up the game.

Friday's victory was followed by the ugly return to the realities of the world: the return of the king of the hill, if you will, as the Sun Devils dynamited the Miners in a double-header.

WITH PLAYERS THE caliber of Bump Wills, son of stolen base peddler Maury Wills, framing the lineup we can expect ASU to do wrong only by the teaspoonfull. Wills, for example, was hitting close to .400, had stolen 20 bases in 23 attempts and eight homers prior to the weekend series with U.T. El Paso.

A near look-alike for his father, he and some professional team will no doubt enter into some long and lasting relationship. "I think I can field, run and throw and hit," Wills said. "But to play in the majors you really have to prove you can hit."

The need to do that is one thing that kept him around ASU this spring instead of signing to play professional. "Playing at ASU gives me more of a pro outlook to the game of baseball," Bump explained. "What I'm trying to do is prove to baseball that I can play under my own merits."

For further motivation, Wills has the moral support of a large Arizona State following. "I went to a Dodger-Giant game as a spectator," he said, "and got bored sitting in the stands. But playing the game is something altogether different. With the crowd behind you, it's great, just like it is in football or basketball or any sport."

About that time, Wills scanned the many empty seats at Dudley Field (Miner games don't draw a 10th as well as the Sun Devils') saying, "If I played here all the time, I don't think I'd hit .260."

In just a matter of innings, however, the Miners emerged batting a 1.000. It definitely was not their average day's work.